Seen from afar, this might have appeared an odd claim. When Netanyahu started his second term in early 2009, the world economy was deep in recession, and Israel had just finished its first ruinous war against Hamas in Gaza. Soon Egypt would plunge into revolution and years of political chaos. A catastrophic civil war would erupt across the northern border in Syria, giving rise to extremist groups and pushing the region into turmoil unprecedented in modern times.

Israel had weathered all of this fairly well. The economy had kept growing, by 5 per cent in 2010, and 4.6 per cent in 2011, despite stagnation among its largest trading partners. Unemployment had hovered around 6.5 per cent, lower than many other advanced economies. On the security front, the army had fought two more wars in Gaza, Palestinians had carried out around of “lone wolf” attacks, and there had been occasional flare-ups of violence on the northern borders. It may not have been quiet, but in relative terms it was peaceful, given the ominous constellation of forces gathering all around: the Islamic State, al-Qaeda, jihadists on the Sinai Peninsula, and a strengthened Hezbollah.

Netanyahu, in other words, could plausibly claim to have steered Israel through a turbulent time in relative peace and prosperity. Yet more than half of the country wanted him gone.

The economy was an oft-cited reason, because years of strong macroeconomic growth had not helped most Israelis. Average wages in 2013 stood at about $28,800, more than $10,000 below the median in the Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD). But it is far more expensive to live in Israel than in other OECD countries. The price of basic consumer goods is 12 per cent higher than the average, for instance.

Likud offered little to such voters. The party didn’t even bother to publish an economic program before the election. On 25 February the state comptroller, the government’s top auditor, blamed the high cost of housing partly on Netanyahu: the government, he said, had failed to come up with a long-term strategy to lower prices. Netanyahu stepped before the cameras to deliver an outlandish response. “When we talk about housing prices, about the cost of living, I do not for a second forget about life itself,” he said. “The biggest threat to our life at the moment is a nuclear-armed Iran.” (It called to mind Joe Biden’s famous quip about former New York mayor